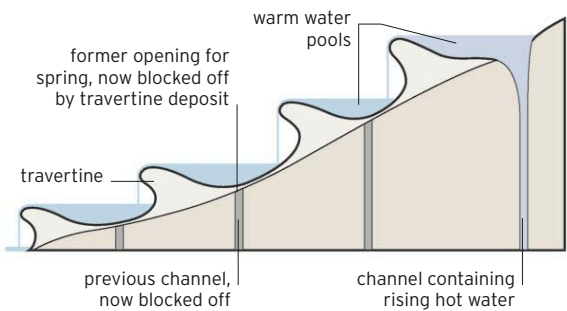




HOW A TRAVERTINE TERRACE FORMS

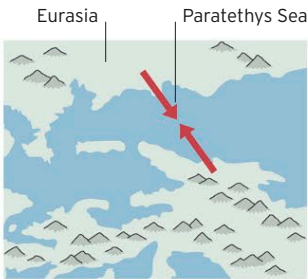
Travertine terraces form when a hot spring containing calcium carbonate erupts on a hill. The flowing water deposits travertine on the slope below the opening, while a buildup of the mineral in the opening eventually chokes it up. A new opening is then forced to develop a little higher up. In this way, the site of the spring gradually shifts uphill, leading to a travertine staircase.



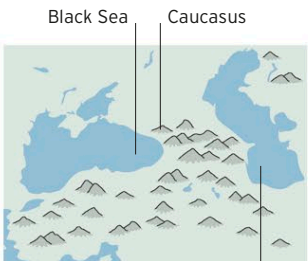
The **springs** flow at about **106 gallons (400 liters)** per second

THE ORIGINS OF THE CAUCASUS

The Caucasus started forming when a landmass comprising parts of present-day Iran, Turkey, Armenia, and nearby countries collided with Eurasia. Around the same time, the Paratethys Sea was split into what are now the Black and Caspian Seas.



ABOUT 30 MILLION YEARS AGO



TODAY

The Caucasus Mountains

A wall of mountains stretching across the meeting point of Asia and Europe



The formidable Caucasus mountain range is situated mainly in the Asian countries of Georgia, Armenia, and Azerbaijan but also partly in European Russia. It consists of two main subranges: the Greater and Lesser Caucasus. The highest peak is Mount Elbrus (in the Russian section) at 18,510 ft (5,642 m). The mountains feature a remarkable array of vegetation zones, ranging from forests and alpine meadows to highland semideserts, and also the world's deepest-known cave, the Krubera Cave in Georgia.

▷ **MAGNETIC MINERAL**

Dashkesan, a region of the Lesser Caucasus, is a source of the iron-rich mineral magnetite, the most magnetic of all minerals.



▷ **SUNRISE VIEW**

The Caucasus are steep, craggy, and relatively young mountains. Many of the peaks in the range carry glaciers—there are more than 2,000 glaciers in the entire range.

